

ELEPHANTS

Largest of all land mammals, elephants are distinguished by their colossal bulk, long flexible trunk, large ears, and curving ivory tusks.

The only members of the Proboscidea, elephants inhabit grassland and forest in tropical Africa and Asia. Sometimes weighing more than five tonnes, elephants have a modified skeleton to bear their weight. The limb bones are extremely stout, and the toes are splayed around a pad of connective tissue. This large frame needs vast amounts of food and elephants eat for up to 16 hours a day, consuming up to 250 kg (550 lb) of vegetation.

EARS, NOSE, AND MOUTH

The elephant's muscular trunk, a fusion of the nose and upper lip, is remarkably versatile and is able to grasp morsels of food. It can also

draw in water and serve as a snorkel when swimming. Sensory organs in the trunk pick up scents and vibrations, so aiding communication. An elephant's large ears are also used for communication and when spread out are a sign of aggression. However, constant flapping helps an elephant to lose heat. Tusks are incisor teeth that grow continually. They are used to dig for roots and salt, clear pathways, and mark territories.

SOCIAL STRUCTURES

Male and female elephants have different social behaviour. Females form herds of related cows and their calves, led by an elderly matriarch. Bull elephants form short-term associations, but will fight with any intruding rival during the breeding season.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	MAMMALIA
ORDER	PROBOSCIDEA
FAMILIES	1
SPECIES	3

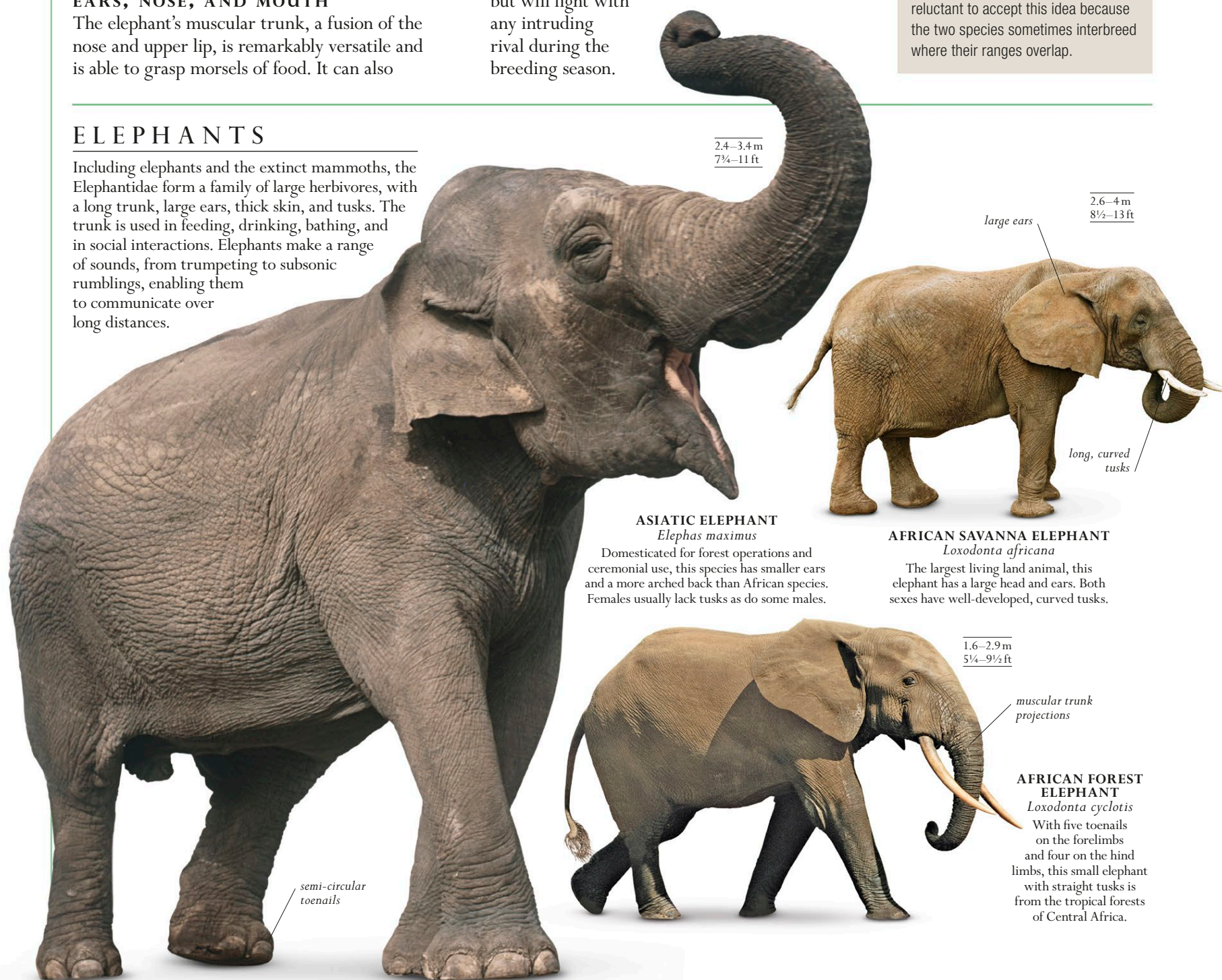
DEBATE

TWO SPECIES OR ONE?

The splitting of the African elephant into two species, the savanna elephant and the smaller forest elephant, was originally based on physical differences, but now there is sufficient genetic evidence to substantiate this division. However, some scientists are reluctant to accept this idea because the two species sometimes interbreed where their ranges overlap.

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Including elephants and the extinct mammoths, the Elephantidae form a family of large herbivores, with a long trunk, large ears, thick skin, and tusks. The trunk is used in feeding, drinking, bathing, and in social interactions. Elephants make a range of sounds, from trumpeting to subsonic rumblings, enabling them to communicate over long distances.



ASIATIC ELEPHANT

Elephas maximus

Domesticated for forest operations and ceremonial use, this species has smaller ears and a more arched back than African species. Females usually lack tusks as do some males.

AFRICAN SAVANNA ELEPHANT

Loxodonta africana

The largest living land animal, this elephant has a large head and ears. Both sexes have well-developed, curved tusks.

AFRICAN FOREST ELEPHANT

Loxodonta cyclotis

With five toenails on the forelimbs and four on the hind limbs, this small elephant with straight tusks is from the tropical forests of Central Africa.